

Medieval medicine

A great deal of medical knowledge was lost when the Roman Empire fell in the 5th century CE. Remnants survived mostly in areas that became part of the Islamic empires after the 7th century. Islamic scholars translated classical medical texts into Arabic and introduced new ideas. From about 1050, word about Arabic medical writing filtered into Europe through various centers of learning, including Salerno in Italy and Toledo in Spain. Techniques such as the washing of wounds and the use of early anesthetics spread. In 1316, Italian physician Mondino da Luzzi wrote the first anatomy textbook in Europe since Roman times.

“Nor may a subdeacon, deacon, or priest practice the art of surgery, which involves cauterizing [treating damaged tissues by burning] and making incisions.”

Decision of the Fourth Lateran Council prohibiting Christian clerics from carrying out surgery, 1215. (Many medieval clergymen practiced medicine, but they were forbidden to shed blood. The rule was originally intended to stop them fighting in war.)